

The Boston Globe

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WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 25, 2026

Legislators take a shot at high energy bills

Proposal would cut \$1 billion from Mass. efficiency program

By Samantha J. Gross and Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

Lawmakers on Beacon Hill moved closer to reining in soaring energy bills with legislation that would slash some \$1 billion in charges for energy efficiency programs that are financed through utility bills.

While the new legislation and similar measures are in reaction to widespread complaints from consumers

about huge electric and gas bills, environmentalists caution that in the long run reductions to programs that reduce consumption will only result in even larger energy bills down the road.

That push and pull will now unfold before the Legislature in the coming months, beginning Thursday when the House is scheduled to vote on the measure that includes significant cuts to the Mass Save program, which is the state's primary tool for moving residents off of fossil fuels. The legislation would also subject expensive utility projects to closer scrutiny and direct the state to refund certain fees it has collected from utilities

to consumers.

The proposal from House Democrats is an "immediate" attempt to save people money on their energy bills, which are among the highest in the nation, House leaders said.

The legislation somewhat tracks a proposal previously filed by Governor Maura Healey, and a spokesperson welcomed the advance of the House legislation.

"Energy costs are too high, and Massachusetts residents need relief," Karissa Hand said.

Massachusetts has high bills in part because of the additional charges for energy efficiency programs, but also due to costs utilities pass on to rate-

payers for costly improvements to their infrastructure such as electric power lines and underground gas pipes.

While the bill before the House on Thursday would subject some of those big projects to closer governmental oversight, it does not address another one that has contributed to natural gas bills: a state program that incentivizes gas companies to repair and replace leaky pipes — at a time when the state is also encouraging homeowners to move away from fossil fuels altogether.

"There's not a single thing in this bill that addresses ending our build-

ENERGY, Page A7

Trump: 'We're winning so much'

In State of the Union, he paints a rosy picture as approval rating falls

By Luke Broadwater, Carl Hulse, and Shawn McCreesh
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Trump, aiming to reverse sliding approval ratings and increasing discontent with his economic and immigration policies, projected in his State of the Union address on Tuesday a version of the United States that is growing, safe, and "winning."

The speech, the longest State of the Union in history, offered few new policy revelations. Instead, Trump provided a rosy picture of the country's economy and mocked Democrats' focus on affordability. He also pushed stalled legislation that purports to address his often repeated — and often debunked — claims of widespread election fraud.

Just days after the Supreme Court struck a blow to his signature tariff policy, Trump called the ruling "totally wrong" and said he would create an "even stronger" solution. And he said that Vice President JD Vance would lead a "war on fraud," which he falsely claimed was prevalent enough to balance the budget if eradicated.

Trump's tone shifted throughout his ad-

TRUMP, Page A4



PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

June Street in Fall River was still unplowed Tuesday morning, with the region getting up to 3 feet of snow on Monday.

Piles and piles of work to be done

Buried cities struggle to clear roads with thousands of people still without power



Adam LaFlash tried to open his car door, on Presidents Avenue in Fall River.

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

Travel bans have been lifted, airports have reopened, and many students will return to class Wednesday in Eastern Massachusetts and Rhode Island after a monster blizzard extended February school vacation.

But the ravages of the historic storm are lingering in the daunting form of widespread power outages, impassable roads, and a massive cleanup with no immediate end in sight.

"We just got walloped," New Bedford Mayor Jon Mitchell said Tuesday following a record 37 inches of snow there. "The city is still effectively shut down. . . . The best thing that people can do is to stay off the roads."

The cleanup effort has become so challenging that Providence Mayor Brett Smiley has asked other leaders in other New England cities — including Michelle Wu in Boston, Hartford, and Bridgeport, Conn. — if they could help the Rhode Island capital remove 3 feet of snow.

"All of our crews are out in every neighborhood, but with historic snow levels I am actively calling in leaders from across the region for additional snow removal support," Smi-

STORM, Page A7

By Amanda Gokee and Amanda Kaufman
GLOBE STAFF

The Trump administration has scrapped plans to convert a warehouse in Merrimack, N.H., into an immigration detention facility, Governor Kelly Ayotte announced Tuesday.

The announcement came after months of protest and pushback from Merrimack residents over the proposal, which was part of a \$38 billion initiative to establish a "new detention model" for President Trump's mass deportation agenda, according to records released earlier this month by Ayotte's office.

The 324,000-square-foot industrial warehouse in Merrimack would have had between 400 to 600 beds for detainees, according to the Department of Homeland Security documents. It would have been part of a new nationwide network with

ICE, Page A6

Plan for ICE facility at N.H. site is dropped

When a dream vacation gets real

Tourists quickly shift gears after an idyllic spot in Mexico explodes in unrest

CHRISTOPHER MUTHER
COMMENTARY

PUERTO VALLARTA — The day started just like any other Sunday in this idyllic tourist hot spot along the Pacific coast. But by 9 a.m., plumes of acrid smoke bloomed in the blue sky, and fires were visible in some of the city's most popular areas. It quickly became an unprecedented day of fear, and, in some cases, terror for both locals and visitors.

Then word quickly spread that the Mexican military had killed Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes, known by his nickname "El Mencho," the head of the New Generation drug cartel, in a shoot-out 180 miles east of Puerto Vallarta in the same state of Jalisco. In a show of resistance, the cartel began setting Puerto Vallarta on fire and littering the highway with spikes, making roads impass-

MUTHER, Page A5



ALFREDO ESTRELLA/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

The military and state police patrolled Tuesday in Puerto Vallarta.



Take it to the banks

Wednesday: Light, light snow. High 37-42. Low 29-34.

Thursday: A bit warmer. High 39-44. Low 20-25.

High tide: 4:53 a.m., 5:40 p.m.
Sunrise: 6:26 Sunset: 5:29

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

DraftKings is cutting jobs as it tightens its belt while facing growing competition from lightly regulated prediction markets. **B5.**

President Volodymyr Zelensky declared that Russia has not "broken Ukrainians" nor triumphed in its war, four years after an invasion that has severely tested Kyiv. **A3.**

TV news anchor Savannah Guthrie said her family is offering up to \$1 million for information that leads to finding her abducted mother. **A2.**

Lawyers warring over the future of Market Basket's leadership will make final pleas about whether deposed chief executive Arthur T. Demoulas should be reinstated. **B5.**

Devra First checks out Ama at the Atlas, a restaurant focused on caregiving, located in a new Allston hotel. **G1.**

VOL. 309, NO. 56
*
Suggested retail price
\$4.00

